

AiCon

2026

International Press Corps

(Photojournalist)

• Background Guide

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Note from the Executive Board.

Dear delegates,

We would like to extend a warm welcome to all of you at AiCon'26. Your participation in this committee is a testament to your interest and dedication to learning and contributing not only to the committee but also to the overall conference.

Photojournalism is more than just clicking pictures; photography is more than just hitting the trigger on your camera. Every picture has the potential to bring a story along with it. It tends to possess the quality of journalistic values, which primarily believes in “**truth**”. In the course of this conference, we will have a great time exploring the art of storytelling through the visual medium, but predominantly focusing on the journalistic capacity of every picture.

The following background guide is going to serve as a comprehensive guide for understanding your camera, creating art with light, determining journalism and photography, and much more.

Irrespective of whether you are a beginner or an expert in the domain of journalism and photography. We urge you to go through it thoroughly and refer to the external information and links attached. Looking forward to “capturing” good times together in the due course of the conference.

Wishing you all the best!

Regards,

Priyanshu Lahoti

Director of Photojournalism

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Assistant Director of Photojournalism

1. REQUIREMENTS

Before we begin, here are some requirements:

- It is mandatory to carry a camera, specifically a DSLR or a mirrorless, only.
Mobile Photography is only allowed if the size and megapixel is of an higher resolution. Example: Above iPhone X, Google Pixel 2, Samsung S22, etc.
- A strict no to compact cameras as well.
- Make sure you carry an SD card with a minimum storage of **16GB to 32GB**.
- Make sure you have sufficient battery in your cameras and if possible, always carry an extra pair of batteries.
- It is advisable to carry your laptop with either an SD card reader or an application to transfer your pictures from your camera. Refer to your brand's website for more information on it.
- Make sure you are responsible for your belongings in the due course of the conference.
- Flashlights won't be necessary as the committees will be assigned in a brightly lit room.
- You can carry a tripod for creative assignments, subject to its requirements.

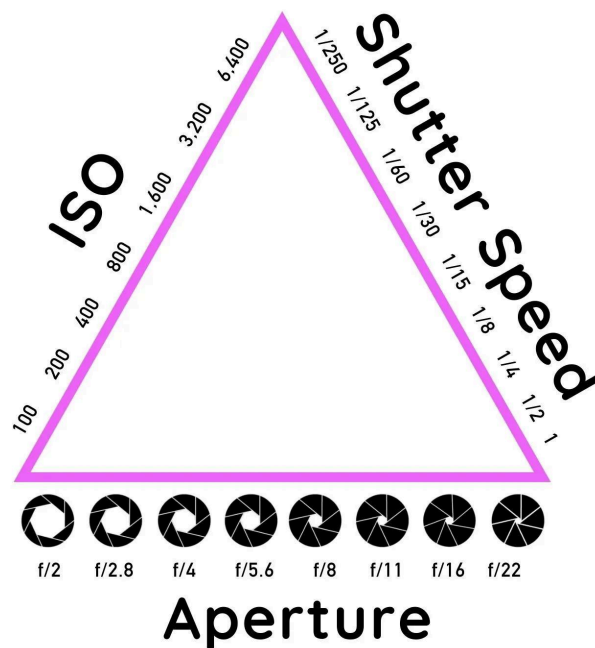
2. Understanding your camera and the basics of Photography.

Various cameras contain different nomenclature for a particular function, which is common to all the cameras. The most basic of photography is understood by looking at the **exposure triangle**.

a. What is the Exposure triangle?

Your picture is a product consisting of three most crucial components of the camera, namely aperture(f/ stops), shutter speed and ISO. These three aspects help construct the exposure(the level of light and dark tones) of your image. Especially when shooting in manual mode, becoming proficient with these three features is crucial to improving as a photographer because they greatly influence the final appearance and impact of your image.

Let's understand these components in depth:



b. Aperture

This is the lens aperture that lets light into the sensor. The more light that enters, the wider the opening. Focus stops, sometimes known as "*f-stops*," are used to measure the aperture's size and are based on the size of the aperture that allows light to enter the camera. The image becomes darker as the f-stop value increases with the size of the hole. In addition to regulating the image's brightness, an aperture is utilized to ascertain the depth of field as well. Low f-stop number and wide aperture: If you want a picture with a sharp subject, you will require a low f-stop number or a wide aperture if you can focus but the background is blurry. Smaller Aperture (High f-stop number): On the other hand, you will need to use a smaller aperture or a higher f-stop number to increase the depth of field if you wish to bring more of the surrounding area into focus. This works well for photography that emphasizes backgrounds, like nature and landscape shots.



c. Shutter speed

The shutter speed of a camera is the rate at which it opens and closes. While slower shutter speeds are used to blur motion, faster shutter speeds enable photographers to freeze motion. While the latter is excellent for catching the motion itself, such as the appearance of a speeding train or the slow movement of stars in the sky, the former is useful in scenarios when you want the subject to be accurately captured mid-motion.

d. ISO(International Organization of Standardization)

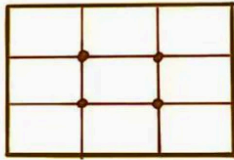
The ISO is the last side of the triangle. This is what influences the sensor's light sensitivity. In low light conditions, a higher ISO is typically employed to enable the sensor to capture as much of the

available light as possible. Conversely, when taking pictures of scenes with a lot of light, a lower ISO is utilised to prevent overexposure. One thing to be cautious of is that higher ISOs might produce a grainy image, particularly when shooting in low light. The term "noise" refers to a grainy, speckled look in your picture. Noise degrades the quality of the picture unless you want it to look grainy.

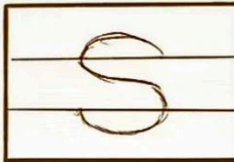


e. Framing/ Composing an Image.

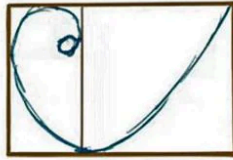
Composition/framing in photography is simply the arrangement of visual elements within a frame. The term composition means 'putting together'. So, to get the perfect shot, the photographer has to organise all the objects in a scene. There are multiple methods of framing or composing an image in a given context or building a narrative. Some composing methods are:



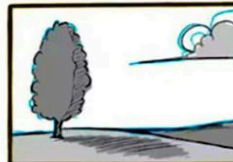
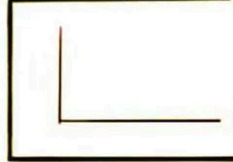
Rule of Thirds



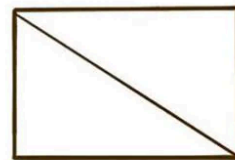
S-Curve



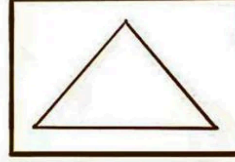
Golden Spiral



L-Shape



Diagonal



Pyramid

3. Understanding Photojournalism

A type of journalism known as photojournalism uses striking photos to convey a news narrative. The first images of battle that appeared in newspapers during the American Civil War and the



Crimean War marked the beginning of photojournalism.

The first image of battle that appeared in newspapers during the American Civil War and the Crimean War

Even yet, the image served solely to support the text and not to take center stage in the narrative.

The 1920s saw the advent of the lighter, more compact 35mm cameras and flashbulbs, which marked the beginning of the "Golden Age" of photojournalism. Artists such as Cartier-Bresson offered authentic depictions of their lives and eras.

Photojournalism plays a crucial role in news media, bridging the gap between written content and the audience's understanding of real-world events. Through impactful visuals, photojournalism communicates the depth, emotions, and reality of a situation that might not be fully captured through words alone. Unlike traditional photography, which focuses on aesthetic and artistic elements, photojournalism emphasizes the documentation of real-life events with accuracy and authenticity. It adheres to strict ethical guidelines to maintain credibility and truthfulness.

Key features of Photojournalism:

1. Storytelling Through Visuals

Photojournalism isn't just about taking pictures; it's about creating a visual narrative. Every photograph should serve as a standalone piece capable of communicating a story, often supported by captions or articles.

2. Emphasis on Truth and Authenticity

A photojournalist must capture events as they happen without staging, manipulating, or altering scenes. Ethical guidelines demand that the images be accurate representations of reality.

3. Impactful Imagery

Photojournalism often captures moments of intense emotion, action, or significance to evoke strong reactions. Iconic photojournalistic works have historically influenced public opinion and policy.

4. Spontaneity and Preparation

Unlike traditional photography, photojournalists often work in unpredictable environments. They must adapt quickly, ensuring they capture key moments under challenging conditions.

5. Contextual Relevance

Photojournalism often ties images to political, social, or cultural contexts, requiring photojournalists to have a deep understanding of the issues they cover.

4. Assessment

a. Committee Pictures

Become the eyes and soul of your committee, capturing the heart of its proceedings. Your goal is to take pictures that go beyond documentation, telling a compelling visual story. We expect you to capture a minimum of **25 pictures** per day.

Rubrics of the assessment

1. Capture the Mood

- Use your lens to reflect the emotional barometer of the committee.
- Showcase the spirit, energy, and ambience of the event through your photos.
- Ensure your images convey the atmosphere vividly.

2. Explore New Techniques

- Experiment with framing, composition, and various photography techniques.
- Push the boundaries of your craft to create unique and compelling visuals.

3. Emotion is Key

- Let each image serve as a vessel for emotion.
- Highlight feelings like passion, engagement, and enthusiasm present in the room.
- Ensure your photos effectively express the sentiments of the moment.

4. Submit the Effort

- Focus on quality over quantity—choose your 35 pictures wisely as we look for quality pictures over quantity.
- Emphasise creativity, effort, and the story behind each shot.
- Treat 'Coverage' as an opportunity to visually chronicle your committee's journey.
- Create images that not only capture moments but also immortalise the essence of the experience.

Editing Criteria:

Very minimal editing is permitted. Making just minor and necessary changes to a photograph after it has been taken is known as minimal editing in photography. Enhancing the image without significantly changing its content or character is the aim of minimal editing. This method is frequently chosen in some kinds of photography where accuracy and authenticity are strongly prized, such as documentary and photojournalistic photography.

Minimal Editing Typically Includes:

1. Basic Adjustments

- Modify fundamental parameters like exposure, contrast, brightness, and color balance.
- Ensure the image accurately represents the scene as it appeared during photography.

2. Cropping

- Perform minimal cropping to enhance composition and eliminate distractions.
- Avoid significantly altering the content of the image.

3. Straightening and Alignment

- Make minor adjustments to correct unintentional tilting or distortion.
- Ensure the image appears level and properly aligned.

4. White Balance

- Adjust colors to appear natural and accurate.
- Maintain the authenticity of the original scene.

5. Basic Retouching

- Remove minor blemishes or distractions that are not integral to the scene, such as dust spots or lens flares.

- Correct minor imperfections while preserving the image's integrity.

b. Creative Assignments

Other than your committee pictures, you will be assigned a minimum of 1 and a maximum of 3 creative assignments. These creative assignments will revolve around a certain thematic scene and test your storytelling and visualisation skills.

The assignments will be announced at the beginning of the respective day.

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5. Reflection and Outcomes:

1. Enhanced Understanding of Photojournalism

- Delegates will grasp the core principles of photojournalism, including ethics, storytelling, and its distinction from basic photography.
- Participants will learn to balance technical skills with the journalistic responsibility of truth and authenticity.

2. Application of Creative and Technical Skills

- Through the 'Coverage' assignment, delegates will experiment with composition, framing, and advanced photography techniques.
- Delegates will practice capturing the emotional essence and mood of events effectively.

3. Improved Visual Storytelling Abilities

- Delegates will develop the skill to convey compelling narratives through visuals.
- Photos taken will highlight emotions, engagement, and the atmosphere of the committee proceedings.

4. Professional Ethics and Minimal Editing Practices

- Participants will adhere to ethical editing guidelines, ensuring integrity in visual representation.
- They will apply minimal editing techniques like basic adjustments, cropping, and white balance correction to preserve authenticity.

5. Recognition of Effort and Creativity

- Delegates will prioritize the story behind their photos over sheer quantity, showcasing creativity and dedication.
- Submitted work will serve as a lasting chronicle of the committee's journey, immortalizing its essence in visual form.

6. Reference/Additional material

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Adorama.<https://www.adorama.com/alc/basic-photography-composition-techniques/>
3. Understanding Journalism: Analyzing Its Many Facets - Indian Media Studies. (2023, September 18). *Indian Media Studies*.
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<https://time.com/6128790/time-best-photojournalism-2021/>
5. Gorlin, A. (2025, October 3). *Photography Composition: The Definitive Guide*. Anton Gorlin Landscape Photography.
<https://antongorlin.com/blog/photography-composition-definitive-guide/>
6. Think Film. (2025, March 26). *What is Visual Storytelling?* [Video]. YouTube.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Fe30DiJOPwY>